

OXFORD AQA INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL ENGLISH LITERATURE

UNIT 4A: LITERARY REPRESENTATIONS

Specimen

Morning

Time allowed: 2 hours 30 minutes

Materials

For this paper you must have:

- An OxfordAQA 12-page answer booklet

Instructions

- Use black ink or black ball-point pen.
- Write the information required on the front of your answer booklet. The **Examining Body** for this paper is Oxford International AQA Exams.
- Do all rough work in your answer booklet. Cross through any work that you do not want to be marked.
- You must answer **all** questions. There is **one** question in Section A and **one** question in Section B.

Information

- The maximum mark for this paper is 50.
- The marks for questions are shown in brackets.

Section A: Prose

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Read carefully the following passage. It is taken from the novel *Waterland* by Graham Swift, first published in 1980.

This is the opening of the novel, narrated by Tom Crick from the perspective of an adult looking back on his childhood. At that time Tom and his family were living in the Fens, a largely agricultural region in the East of England.

Write an analysis of this extract, in which you focus on the representation of children and culture.

[25 marks]

1. *About the Stars and the Sluice**

‘And don’t forget,’ my father would say, as if he expected me at any moment to up and leave to seek my fortune in the wide world, ‘whatever you learn about people, however bad they turn out, each one of them has a heart, and each one of them was once a tiny baby sucking his mother’s milk . . .’

Fairy-tale words; fairy-tale advice. But we lived in a fairy-tale place. In a lock-keeper’s* cottage, by a river, in the middle of the Fens. Far away from the wide world. And my father, who was a superstitious man, liked to do things in such a way as would make them seem magical and occult. So he would always set his eel-traps* at night. Not because eel-traps cannot be set by day, but because the mystery of darkness appealed to him. And one night, in midsummer, in 1937, we went with him, Dick and I, to set traps near Stott’s Bridge. It was hot and windless. When the traps had been set we lay back on the river-bank. Dick was fourteen and I was ten. The pumps were tump-tumping, as they do, incessantly, so that you scarcely notice them, all over the Fens, and frogs were croaking in the ditches. Up above, the sky swarmed with stars which seemed to multiply as we looked at them. And as we lay, Dad said: ‘Do you know what the stars are? They are the silver dust of God’s blessing. They are little broken-off bits of heaven. God cast them down to fall on us. But when he saw how wicked we were, he changed his mind and ordered the stars to stop. Which is why they hang in the sky but seem as though at any time they might drop . . .’

For my father, as well as being a superstitious man, had a knack for telling stories. Made-up stories, true stories; soothing stories, warning stories; stories with a moral or with no point at all; believable stories and unbelievable stories; stories which were neither one thing nor the other. It was a knack which ran in his family. But it was a knack which my mother had too – and perhaps he really acquired it from her. Because when I was very small it was my mother who first told me stories, which, unlike my father, she got from books as well as out of her head, to make me sleep

at night.

And since my mother's death, which was six months before we lay by the eel-traps under the stars, my father's yen for the dark, his nocturnal restlessness, had grown more besetting. As if he were constantly brooding on some story yet to be told. So I would see him sometimes, inspecting his vegetable patch by the moonlight, or talking to his roosting chickens, or pacing up and down by the lock-gates or the sluice, his movements marked by the wandering ember of his cigarette.

We lived in a lock-keeper's cottage by the River Leem, which flows out of Norfolk into the Great Ouse. And no one needs telling that the land in that part of the world is flat. Flat, with an unrelieved and monotonous flatness, enough of itself, some might say, to drive a man to unquiet and sleep-defeating thoughts. From the raised banks of the Leem, it stretched away to the horizon, its uniform colour, peat-black, varied only by the crops that grew upon it – grey-green potato leaves, blue-green beet leaves, yellow-green wheat; its uniform levelness broken only by the furrowed and dead-straight lines of ditches and drains, which, depending on the state of the sky and the angle of the sun, ran like silver, copper or golden wires across the fields and which, when you stood and looked at them, made you shut one eye and fall prey to fruitless meditations on the laws of perspective.

And yet this land, so regular, so prostrate, so tamed and cultivated, would transform itself, in my five- or six-year-old mind, into an empty wilderness. On those nights when my mother would be forced to tell me stories, it would seem that in our lock-keeper's cottage we were in the middle of nowhere; and the noise of the trains passing on the lines to King's Lynn, Gildsey and Ely was like the baying of a monster closing in on us in our isolation.

A fairy-tale land, after all.

King's Lynn and **Ely** are real places in Eastern England. **Norfolk** is an English county, and the **Ouse** is an English river. **Gildsey** and the **River Leem** are fictional.

* **sluice**: a channel or drain for water

* **lock-keeper**: someone employed to supervise the working of a lock (a series of gates that regulate the flow of water)

* **eel**: a fish with a long, snake-like body

Section B: Poetry

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Read carefully the following poem by Miroslav Holub, first published in 1967, and complete the task below.

Write an analysis of this poem in which you explore the significance of Holub's representation of war.

[25 marks]

The Fly

She sat on a willow-trunk
watching
part of the battle of Crécy*,
the shouts,
the gasps,
the groans,
the trampling and the tumbling.

During the fourteenth charge
of the French cavalry
she mated
with a brown-eyed male fly
from Vadincourt*.

She rubbed her legs together
as she sat on a disembowelled horse
meditating
on the immortality of flies.

With relief she alighted
on the blue tongue
of the Duke of Clervaux*.

When silence settled
and only the whisper of decay
softly circled the bodies

and only
a few arms and legs
still twitched jerkily under the trees,

she began to lay her eggs

on the single eye
of Johann Uhr,
the Royal Armourer*.

And thus it was
that she was eaten by a swift*
fleeing
from the fires of Estrées*.

From the Czech (trans. George Theiner)

* the battle of **Crécy**, fought in 1346 near Crécy in northern France, was an English victory over the French army during what was called the Hundred Years' War

* **Vadincourt**: a town in northern France

* **Clervaux**: a town in northern Luxembourg, not far from the French border

* **armourer**: someone who makes armour and weapons, especially for soldiers in battle

* **swift**: a small fast-flying swallow-like bird

* **Estrées**: a village in northern France

END OF QUESTIONS

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Question 2 source: Miroslav Holub, Poems Before & After: Collected English Translations, trans. Ian & Jarmila Milner et al. (Bloodaxe Books, 2006)

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